



Litmus test: If in the 1980s and during a part of the 1990s, players burnished their credentials through performances against the mighty West Indies, Australia now serves as the yardstick that separates the men from the boys. GETTYIMAGES

NEW CHAPTER, OLD RIVALS

England may be the old enemy, but for Australia, **India is a clear** and present danger.

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The willow game's rivalries, marinated in history, angst, stunning performances, and seasoned with perhaps a touch of geopolitics, have always stirred interest in cricket's ardent devotees. Straight up is the Ashes, pitting the mother country England against a former colony Australia, while both remain tied together with the threads of the

erstwhile Commonwealth Empire.

Then we get the feverish high-pitched notes of India and Pakistan, neighbours split by the Radcliffe Line and a seemingly eternal animosity yet fused by a shared history, cuisine, language and pop-culture references. **This is a sport that comes with excessive baggage even before the players have stepped onto the turf.**

In this cauldron of emotions, throw in India and Australia, and you get a rivalry, at least in recent times,

second to none. This is cricket at its best, with stars on either side striving hard, doing the impossible, and playing a game that defines their legacy. If in the 1980s and during a part of the 1990s, players burnished their credentials through performances against the mighty West Indies, Australia now serves as the yardstick that separates the men from the boys. Equally, a tour of India is deemed a difficult proposition even if New Zealand proved otherwise with its recent 3-0 sweep in the Tests.